Dog boarding checklist.

A short checklist for your dog's first boarding stay, built from veterinary school and AVMA guidance. Tick items off as you go, or print it.

Choosing the facility

- [ ] Tour the facility and look at how clean and organized it is.[1]
- [ ] Ask how often the dogs are fed and whether they get enough exercise.[1, 3]
- [ ] Ask how the day runs, and whether veterinary services are available.[1, 3]
- [ ] Notice whether staff welcome questions and tours, and how loud it is.[1]

Before you book

- [ ] Check in with your regular vet, especially if your dog is elderly, medically fragile or highly anxious.[1]
- [ ] Ask the facility which vaccines it requires, and confirm your dog is up to date.[1, 3]

In the days before

- [ ] Ask the facility which forms it needs, including its emergency authorization form.[2]
- [ ] Choose an emergency contact who can act for you, and if your dog is microchipped, add that person to the microchip registry.[2]

- [ ] Write down your dog's exercise routine, favorite games or toys, and any medical conditions that could lead to an emergency.[2]

Packing day

- [ ] Your dog's regular food for the stay plus a few extra days, with clear written feeding instructions.[2]
- [ ] Any medication and supplements your dog already gets, as your vet directs, plus a note on which treats are okay.[2]
- [ ] A comfort item such as a worn T-shirt or a favorite toy, if your dog will not chew it up.[1]
- [ ] Vaccination records, including proof of rabies, and up-to-date medical information.[2]
- [ ] Every way to reach you, plus your regular vet's name and contact details.[2]

After pickup

- [ ] Expect a short readjustment: extra attention, more sleep, or a day to settle back in.[1]
- [ ] Call your vet if vomiting, diarrhea, coughing, lethargy or big behavior changes last or are severe.[1]

> **Talk to your vet.** Your vet can check vaccines, flag anything specific to your dog and advise before a first stay. Bring this list to your appointment.

Want the reasons behind each item? Read How do you prepare your dog for boarding for the first time?.

Sources.

1. Texas A&M University College of Veterinary Medicine & Biomedical Sciences, Pet Talk. Planning ahead: reducing stress when boarding your pet. 2026.
2. American Veterinary Medical Association. Ensuring your pet is protected when you're away. AVMA, n.d.
3. Texas A&M University College of Veterinary Medicine & Biomedical Sciences, Pet Talk. Holiday travel: should pets come along? 2017.